

IT Recruitment Process

Complete Documentation — End-to-End Hiring Guide

From Job Posting to Onboarding · ATS Screening · HR Screening · Technical Interviews · Offer & BGV

Document Type	Recruitment Process Guide
Scope	IT Companies — Software Engineering Roles
Audience	Candidates, HR Teams, Hiring Managers

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1. Recruitment Process Overview

The IT recruitment process in most companies follows a structured 9-stage pipeline. Each stage serves a specific filtering or evaluation purpose, and candidates can be eliminated at any point. Understanding each stage helps both candidates prepare effectively and hiring teams run a consistent, fair process.

1

Job Requirement Analysis

Define role, skills, budget, team fit

2

Job Posting & Sourcing

LinkedIn, job boards, referrals, campus

3

Resume / CV Screening

ATS filters + recruiter shortlisting

4

HR Screening Call

Salary, notice period, culture fit

5

Technical Assessment

Coding test, take-home, HackerRank

6

Technical Interview(s)

DSA, system design, code review

7

Managerial / Culture Round

Leadership, teamwork, scenario Qs

8

Offer & Negotiation

CTC, stock, perks, joining date

9

BGV + Onboarding

Docs, background check, induction

Note: Rejection can occur at any stage. The pipeline is not guaranteed to be sequential — some companies combine stages or skip certain rounds for experienced hires.

2. Database Table Architecture

The recruitment system is built on 7 core tables. The APPLICATION table is the central join entity that links a CANDIDATE to a JOB_POSTING and drives the downstream pipeline.

Table	Key Fields	Purpose
JOB_POSTING	id, title, department, location, status, recruiter_id (FK)	Stores all open and closed job listings
CANDIDATE	id, full_name, email, phone, current_ctc, expected_ctc, notice_period_days	Master record for every applicant
APPLICATION	id, job_id (FK), candidate_id (FK), status, source, referred_by (FK)	Central join — one row per candidate per role
RECRUITMENT_STAGE	id, application_id (FK), stage_name, stage_status, scheduled_date, conducted_by (FK)	Tracks each interview/assessment round
INTERVIEW_FEEDBACK	id, stage_id (FK), interviewer_id (FK), rating, recommendation, feedback	Stores per-round interviewer feedback
OFFER	id, application_id (FK), offered_ctc, joining_date, status	Offer details and acceptance status
EMPLOYEE	id, full_name, email, role, department	Internal staff — recruiters and interviewers

Key Relationships

Relationship	Cardinality
JOB_POSTING → APPLICATION	One job can receive many applications (1:N)
CANDIDATE → APPLICATION	One candidate can apply to multiple jobs (1:N)
APPLICATION → RECRUITMENT_STAGE	Each application spawns multiple stage records (1:N)
RECRUITMENT_STAGE → INTERVIEW_FEEDBACK	Each stage may have multiple feedback entries (1:N)
APPLICATION → OFFER	A successful application results in one offer (1:1)

3. Candidate Application Form Design

The application form is a 4-step wizard that maps directly to database fields. Each step collects a logical group of information to reduce cognitive load on the candidate.

Step 1: Personal Information

- Full name (first + last)
- Email address
- Phone number
- Current city
- Open to relocation (Yes / No / Discussion)
- LinkedIn profile URL
- Portfolio / GitHub URL

Step 2: Work Experience

- Total experience (years)
- Employment type (Full-time / Contract / Intern)
- Current company & designation
- Current CTC (LPA)
- Expected CTC (LPA)
- Notice period (days)
- How did you hear about this role?
- Referral employee name / ID

Step 3: Skills & Technical Profile

- Primary skills (tag input — add/remove)
- Primary programming language
- System design experience level
- Cover letter / work summary (optional)

Step 4: Resume & Declaration

- Resume upload (PDF or DOCX, max 5 MB)
- Work samples upload (optional)
- Declaration checkbox — accuracy + BGV consent

4. Post-Submission: What Happens Next

After clicking Submit, candidates enter a defined pipeline with approximate timelines. Understanding this helps set realistic expectations and know when to follow up.

Timeline	Stage	What Happens	Candidate Action
Day 0	Auto-confirmation	System emails application ID immediately	Save the email + application ID
Day 0–1	ATS screening	Keywords scored, below-threshold auto-rejected	No action needed
Day 3–7	Recruiter review	Human manually reviews shortlisted profiles	No action; follow up after Day 7
Day 7–10	HR screening call	15–30 min call on salary, notice, availability	Prepare CTC, notice period, intro
Day 10–14	Technical assessment	Online coding test or take-home task sent	Complete within given deadline
Day 14–21	Technical interviews	1–3 rounds: DSA, system design, code review	Prepare algorithms + architecture
Day 21–25	Managerial round	Culture fit, leadership, scenario questions	Prepare STAR-format stories
Day 25–30	Offer & negotiation	Verbal offer → formal letter, 3–7 days to accept	Negotiate CTC and joining date
Day 30–60	BGV + onboarding	Background check, docs, device, induction	Submit documents promptly

5. ATS Screening — How It Works

An Applicant Tracking System (ATS) is the software layer that sits between the submitted resume and a human recruiter's eyes. It parses resume text, scores it against job description keywords, and filters candidates automatically — often within minutes of submission.

How the Scoring Works

Category	Weight	What ATS Checks
Must-have technical skills	60%	Exact keyword match from JD's required skills list
Nice-to-have skills	25%	Additional tools, frameworks, methodologies
Experience signals	15%	Years of experience, seniority keywords, team size

Score Thresholds

Score	Outcome	What Happens
75% and above	Active shortlist	Surfaced to recruiter for immediate review
60–74%	Manual review pile	Recruiter may or may not get to it
Below 60%	Auto-rejected	Automated rejection email sent

Critical Rules for ATS-Friendly Resumes

- Use exact keyword strings from the JD — 'Kubernetes' and 'K8s' are different strings to a naive parser.
- Avoid multi-column layouts, tables, and text-in-images — these often produce garbled text during PDF parsing.
- Place a dedicated plain-text Skills section — skills buried in bullets or tables may not register.
- Include both long form and abbreviation — e.g., 'Amazon Web Services (AWS)' covers both variants.
- State years of experience clearly per role — '2020–2024' parses better than 'recent' or 'several years'.
- Keyword frequency matters — mentioning a skill once scores less than mentioning it across sections.

6. ATS Shortlisting Criteria

Beyond keyword matching, ATS systems evaluate multiple dimensions when ranking candidates. The weights below reflect typical IT company configurations for software engineering roles.

Criterion	Weight	Detail
Technical skill keywords	60%	Must-have skills carry 3x weight vs nice-to-have. Exact string matching — no semantic inference.
Years of experience	10%	Numbers near keywords infer seniority. Gaps reduce effective count.
Job title relevance	8%	Most recent and longest-held titles compared to target role for seniority alignment.
Education & degree	6%	Degree level and field checked against JD requirements. Less weight for experienced hires.
Resume completeness	6%	Missing standard sections (summary, exp, skills, education) lower confidence score.
Certifications & tools	4%	Cloud/platform certs (AWS, GCP, Azure) corroborate skill claims. Recency matters.
Location & availability	3%	City/state checked for on-site roles. Remote roles skip this criterion.
Employment stability	3%	Average tenure < 12 months flagged. Gaps > 6 months noted for recruiter.

Signals that boost ranking	Red flags that lower score
• Skills mirror JD wording exactly • Job titles match seniority level • Years of exp >= JD requirement • Quantified impact (% , numbers) • Relevant certs listed with year	• Skills in image or table format • Missing must-have keywords • Job-hopping pattern (<1 yr each) • Unexplained employment gaps • Multi-column resume layout

7. Recruiter Manual Resume Review

After the ATS passes a profile, a human recruiter spends 6–10 seconds on a first pass, then 2–3 minutes on a deeper read if the initial scan passes. Here is exactly what they look for at each stage.

First 6–10 Seconds: The Quick Scan

Check	What Recruiter Looks For	Pass Condition
Job title	Does most recent title match role seniority?	Senior → Senior, not Junior → Senior
Years of exp	Is it stated upfront in summary?	Number visible in first 3 lines
Company names	Are they recognisable / credible?	Known IT employer or reputable startup
Tech stack	Are core skills visible above the fold?	Java / Python / AWS visible in summary
Formatting	Is the resume clean and readable?	Single column, clear sections, no clutter

Deeper 2–3 Minute Review

- Career progression — does the arc make sense? Junior → SWE → Senior is expected.
- Quantified impact — numbers convert claims into evidence. '40% latency reduction' beats 'improved performance'.
- Leadership evidence — team size mentored, projects owned, cross-functional influence.
- Employment gaps — any gap over 6 months gets a mental note and will be probed in the HR call.
- Short tenures — under 12–18 months per role is a yellow flag. Two or more in a row is a pattern.
- Soft-skill filler — phrases like 'passionate about clean code' or 'team player' waste space and signal lack of substance.
- CTC bracket — if visible, checked against budget. If not visible, confirmed in HR call.

8. HR Screening Call — Preparation Guide

The HR screening call is 15–30 minutes and answers three questions from the recruiter's side: Can you do the job? Can the company afford you? Will you actually join? Preparing for each dimension separately is the most effective approach.

What to Know Before the Call

Your exact current CTC: Base + variable + benefits breakdown — not an approximation

Notice period: Exact days per contract, buyout policy, whether you can commit to a date

Expected CTC range: Researched against Naukri Salary Insights, LinkedIn Salary, AmbitionBox

The job description: Re-read it the morning of the call — reference it when asked about the role

Your 60-second intro: Practised out loud: current role + key achievement + why this role

Why this company: One specific, genuine reason — product, tech stack, recent initiative

Your pipeline status: Where else you are interviewing and at what stage

Day-of Logistics

- Quiet space with no background noise or interruptions
- Good internet connection — wired preferred, headphones recommended
- Your submitted resume in front of you (same version)
- Notepad ready — write down recruiter's name and stated next steps
- Join 2 minutes early — punctuality is noted

Do this	Avoid this
• Give a specific joining date • State CTC as a researched range • Ask 2–3 thoughtful questions • Frame exit as opportunity pull • Mention competing offers honestly	• Say 'any salary is fine' • Badmouth current employer • Ask about leaves/perks first • Overcommit on notice period • Be vague or say 'I'll think about it'

9. Common HR Questions & Model Answers

Q: Tell me about yourself.

Opening

What they are really asking: Can you communicate clearly? Do you have a coherent career narrative?

How to answer: Present → Past → Future structure. Current role + key achievement (30 sec) → most relevant prior experience (20 sec) → why this role is the logical next step (20 sec). Keep to 60–90 seconds. Never start from education or read your resume aloud.

Q: What is your current and expected CTC?

Salary

What they are really asking: Is this candidate within budget? Will the offer convert them?

How to answer: State current CTC accurately — it will be verified in BGV. Give an expected range 20–30% above current, anchored on market research. Example: 'Currently at 14 LPA. Based on this role's scope and market benchmarks, I'm targeting 18–20 LPA.' Never say 'anything is fine' — it kills negotiating leverage.

Q: What is your notice period?

Logistics

What they are really asking: Does this timeline work for the team's hiring plan?

How to answer: Be precise. 'My notice period is 60 days per contract. I can discuss buyout with my employer but cannot guarantee it. I am available to join by [specific date].' If you have flexibility, mention it — it is a genuine differentiator.

Q: Why are you looking to change jobs?

Motivation

What they are really asking: Are you running away from problems or running toward an opportunity?

How to answer: Frame it as a pull, not a push. Lead with what attracts you to this role — new tech stack, domain, or problem scale. If leaving for negative reasons, describe neutrally: 'My current scope has plateaued after 3 years. I am looking for teams working on larger-scale distributed systems.' Never badmouth your employer.

Q: Why do you want to join our company specifically?

Culture fit

What they are really asking: Have you researched us, or are you spraying applications?

How to answer: Reference something specific — a recent product launch, an engineering blog post, a tech initiative you admire. One specific observation beats five generic ones. Spend 15 minutes on their website and engineering blog before the call.

Q: Do you have any questions for me?

Engagement

What they are really asking: Is this candidate engaged, or passive?

How to answer: Always have 2–3 questions ready. Best options: (1) 'What does success look like in the first 90 days?' (2) 'What is the biggest technical challenge the team is solving right now?' (3) 'What is the next step and typical timeline?' Never say 'no, I think you covered everything.'

10. Key Dos and Don'ts — Complete Summary

Resume & ATS

	Action
Yes	Mirror exact JD keyword phrasing in your skills section
Yes	Use a single-column, plain-text-parseable resume format
Yes	Quantify every achievement with numbers, percentages, or scale
Yes	List certifications with issuer and year (e.g., AWS SA Assoc. – 2024)
No	Use multi-column layouts, tables, or skill-bar graphics
No	Put key skills only inside image files or header/footer regions
No	Assume 'NodeJS' and 'Node.js' mean the same thing to an ATS

HR Screening Call

	Action
Yes	Research the company — read their engineering blog and recent news
Yes	Prepare a 60-second intro and practise it out loud before the call
Yes	Give a specific, date-anchored answer for your joining availability
Yes	Frame your reason for leaving as opportunity pull, not problem escape
No	Say 'any salary is fine' — it destroys your negotiating position
No	Badmouth your current employer in any form
No	Ask about leave policy or perks before asking about the role itself
No	Overcommit to a shorter notice period you cannot actually deliver

General Process

	Action
Yes	Save your application ID and reference it in all follow-up emails
Yes	Follow up once after the stated review timeline has passed
Yes	Prepare STAR-format stories for behavioural and managerial rounds
Yes	Ask thoughtful questions at the end of every interview round
No	Apply to many roles without customising the resume per JD
No	Fabricate or exaggerate CTC — it is verified in background check
No	Accept verbal offers without getting the formal letter in writing